more than staying alive. That noon, writes Haider, Humayun had 17,000 men under his command; now, he rode alone upon a borrowed horse,[11] his head bare and his feet unshod.

It wasn't just his shoes Humayun had lost, but also his spirit. Riding ragged from Kannauj towards his capital, Agra, he began to speak of the women in his harem in doleful, ominous tones. Would it not be best to avert the dangers of defeat, the fate worse than death . . .? Humayun's youngest brother, Hindal, told the emperor to stop it. 'What it would be to your Majesty to kill a mother and a sister . . .!' cried the chivalrous prince. 'So long as there is life in me, I will fight in their service. I have hope in the most high God, that, poor fellow as I am, I may pour out my life's blood for my mother and my sisters.'[12]

The emperor was not wrong to worry, however. News of his defeat was travelling faster than he was: less than halfway to Agra, the retreating army was stopped in its tracks by 3000 villagers of Bhangaon, these 'peasants', writes Jouher, being 'in the habit of plundering a defeated army'. Humayun sent orders for his brothers Hindal and Askari, with their cousin Yadgar Nasir, to disperse the villagers, but the men began to squabble instead. Askari was fed up of fighting and 'delayed to proceed', at which Yadgar Nasir took out his horsewhip and began to ply it upon the recalcitrant prince, shouting that things would never have come to such a wretched pass if it weren't for Askari's 'discord'.[13]

His brothers, it is true, had not been pillars of support during Humayun's brief reign. Now, in almost as much danger of killing each other as of being waylaid by opportunist marauders – 'sedition raised its head on every side', writes Abul Fazl – the princes mustered the wits to drive back the men of Bhangaon, galloped to Agra, and from there, 'broken and dispirited',[14] fled north.

So it was that in July 1540, a decade after Babur died and left his progeny to grow his Hindustani kingdom – a brushstroke of land running south-east from Peshawar to Patna, with its capital in Agra, and precarious toeholds in Rajasthan and Malwa – his family huddled in Lahore, the only Hindustani city they had left, to see how, *if*, they might salvage their inheritance. Humayun, Askari and Hindal each arrived in Lahore separately, and set up separate camps. The fourth brother, Kamran, was already in the city, having